

Seawall height in West Palm Beach

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

WEST PALM BEACH • PALM BEACH COUNTY

No minimum set in local code

West Palm Beach's zoning code sets no minimum or maximum seawall height. Its shoreline rules cover where walls go and require riprap or vegetation with replacement bulkheads, not elevation.

The detail

MINIMUM	None set - Ch. 94 Sec. 94-378(b) Shoreline stabilization covers hardening only
REPLACEMENT BULKHEADS	Must consist of or include sloping rip-rap or permeable materials together with vegetation - Sec. 94-378(b)(4)
DOCKS VS. SEAWALL	No portion of a dock may extend above the top of the bulkhead it is attached to - Sec. 94-313
SETBACK	Residential structures on tidal waterfront lots sit at least 25 ft back from the mean high water mark, reduced to 15 ft where a seawall exists on or behind that mark - Sec. 94-305(c)(2)
HARDENING IS A LAST RESORT	Seawalls and other hardening may be used only where erosion threatens life and property and vegetation has already failed to stabilize the shoreline - Sec. 94-378(b)(3)
LAKE WORTH CIRCULATION	No new dock or other structure may be approved that would constrict water circulation in Lake Worth. One dock per lot, with dated written approval from DEP, the Army Corps and/or SFWMD at permit - Sec. 94-378(a)(2), 94-313

Where this comes from: City of West Palm Beach Code, Ch. 94 Zoning and Land Development Regulations (enCodePlus), Secs. 94-378, 94-313, 94-305

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1

Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 **Get the existing elevation surveyed**

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 **Ask what triggers the requirement**

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 **Ask about building higher now**

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.